



SUNWAY COLLEGE • INNOVATION FEST 2026

The Academic Poster & Presentation Playbook

Standard poster size • what to write • how to present • how to win over the judges

A complete briefing for participating students

What Is an Academic Poster?

A poster is a visual summary of your project that tells the whole story in under 5 minutes and starts a conversation with the judges. It is not an essay pinned to a wall.

A great poster does 3 jobs



Communicate

A passer-by understands your project in 30 seconds, even from a distance.



Converse

It gives judges natural entry points to ask questions you can answer well.



Convince

It shows evidence: results, data, and a working demo.



The golden rule

“A poster is an illustrated abstract, not a paper on a wall.”

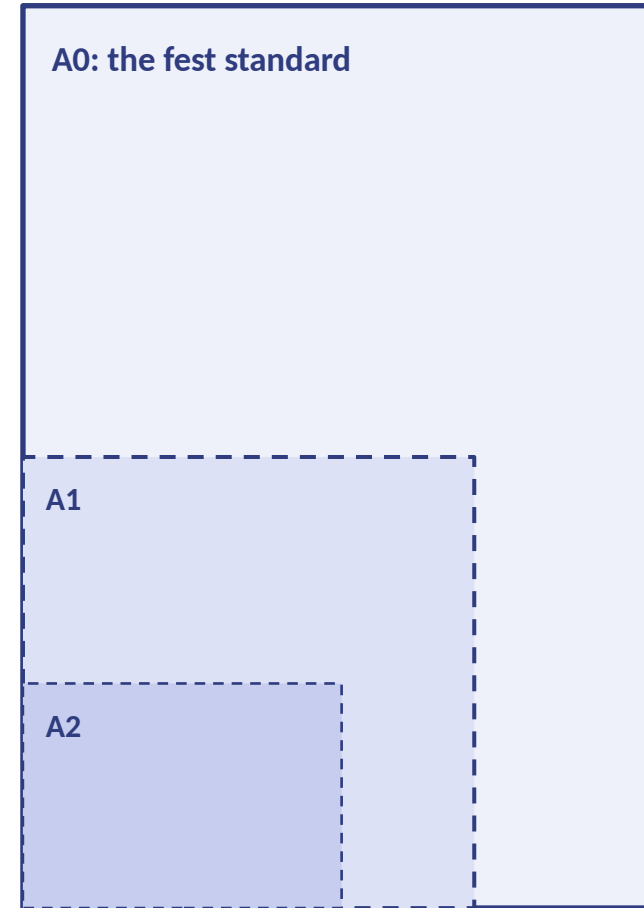
Judges spend 3–5 minutes per poster. If they must read paragraphs to understand it, you have already lost points. Visuals first, words second.

Poster Size: A0 Portrait

841 × 1189 mm

33.1 × 46.8 inches. ISO A0, portrait orientation

- Design at true A0 size from day one. Set your PowerPoint / Canva / Illustrator page to 841 × 1189 mm before adding anything.
- Export as PDF at 300 DPI for printing; check every image looks sharp at 100% zoom.
- Prefer matte paper, since glossy reflects venue lights and becomes hard to read.
- Print at least 2 days early. Printers get crowded before fests, and you may need one reprint.



Shown to scale: A1 is half of A0, A2 is a quarter. If organizers announce a different size, always follow the official brief.

Anatomy of a Winning Layout



Reading flow: top → bottom, then left → right



Use 3 columns

Three vertical columns is the standard for A0 portrait. Judges read each column top to bottom, moving left to right.



Follow the 40 / 40 / 20 rule

Roughly 40% visuals (charts, diagrams, photos), at most 40% text, and at least 20% empty white space. Empty space is a feature, not a waste.



Put results at eye level

Your strongest result or key chart belongs in the top-right area (highlighted gold in the mockup), where the eye lands after the title.



Add a QR code

Link to your demo video, GitHub repo, or full report. It shows depth without cluttering the poster.



Number your sections

1. Introduction → 2. Objectives → ... Numbers guide judges through your story in the right order.

The 8 Standard Sections

1. Title

≤ 2 lines, ≤ 15 words. Say what it does, not just its name: “SmartAgro: IoT Soil Monitoring for Small Farms”.

3. Introduction / Problem

50–80 words. What real problem exists, who suffers from it, why it matters.

5. Methodology

How you built it, best shown as a system diagram or flowchart, not paragraphs.

7. Conclusion & Future Work

50–70 words. What you proved + 2–3 realistic next steps.

2. Authors & Affiliation

Full names, program, college logo. Add your supervisor if you have one.

4. Objectives

3–4 short bullets. What exactly your project set out to achieve.

6. Results / Demo

Charts, screenshots, measured numbers. The most important section, so give it the most space.

8. References & Contact

3–6 key sources, small font, plus email / QR code.

The Title Banner: Logos, Names, Formatting

PARTNER
LOGO
(e.g. BCU)

AirSathi: Hyperlocal Air Quality Alerts for Kathmandu Using Low-Cost Sensors

Udit Kumar Mahato, Teammate Two, Teammate Three

Sunway College Kathmandu, Maitidevi, Kathmandu, Nepal · Supervisor: Name Surname

COLLEGE
LOGO
(Sunway)



Logos: one each side, same height

College logo on one side, partner university (e.g. BCU) on the other. Equal height, high-resolution PNG, never stretched.



Title centered between the logos

Bold, 72–100 pt on A0, max 2 lines. Leave clear space so the title never touches a logo.



Team names on one line

All members, separated by commas, in order of contribution. Supervisor goes after the affiliation.



Underline = the presenter

The underlined name marks the presenting author. It is the standard convention, so underline whoever leads the pitch, nothing else.



Affiliation below the names

One smaller line: college, city, country. If members are from different institutions, use superscript numbers after each name.



Keep the banner slim

The whole banner takes at most 10–15% of poster height. It introduces the work; it is not the work.

Writing Rules That Judges Reward

800

words maximum on the whole poster

Aim for 300–600. Every sentence you cut makes the remaining ones stronger. If a detail matters, say it aloud during your pitch instead of printing it.

“If everything is on the poster, there is nothing left for you to say.”



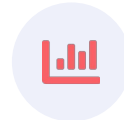
Bullets, not paragraphs

Max 2 lines per bullet. Judges scan; they do not read blocks of text.



Active voice, plain words

“We built...”, “The sensor detects...”. Cut jargon a non-expert would not know.



Show numbers as charts

“Accuracy improved 23%” as a labeled bar chart beats a sentence every time.



Label everything

Every chart needs a title, axis labels, and units. Unlabeled charts cost easy points.



Proofread × 3

One typo in the title can undo a month of work. Have two other people check it.

Font Sizes: Readable From 2 Meters

Poster Title

Section Header

Body text looks like this: short, scannable bullet points that a judge can read while standing 1.5 to 2 meters away from your poster.

Caption / reference text is the smallest, used only for sources and photo credits.

(Relative sizes shown; actual poster sizes in the table →)

Element	Size on A0
Poster title	72–100 pt, bold
Authors / affiliation	40–48 pt
Section headers	40–48 pt, bold
Body text	24–32 pt
Captions & references	18–24 pt

- Maximum 2 font families: one for headings, one for body.
- Sans-serif (Calibri, Arial, Lato) is safest for body text.
- Test: print one section on A4 and read it from 2 m away.

Design Rules: Make It Look Professional



Max 2–3 colors

Pick one dominant color plus one accent. Dark text on a light background always wins under venue lighting.



Align everything to a grid

Columns the same width, equal gaps, straight edges. Misalignment reads as carelessness, and judges notice instantly.



One idea per visual

Each chart or diagram should make exactly one point. If a figure needs a paragraph to explain, simplify the figure.



High-resolution images only

Photos and screenshots need ~300 DPI at print size. A pixelated image on A0 is visible from across the room.



Consistency is credibility

Same bullet style, same header style, same chart colors everywhere. Consistency signals a disciplined team.



Brand it lightly

College logo top corner, team name, consistent footer. Light branding: the project stays the hero.

AVOID THESE

7 Mistakes That Sink Posters Every Year



The wall of text

Full paragraphs copied from your report. Judges skip them entirely.



Tiny fonts

Body text under 24 pt is unreadable at poster distance.



Pixelated images

Screenshots stretched to A0 without checking resolution.



Rainbow chaos

5+ colors, clashing backgrounds, decorative fonts.



Unlabeled charts

No axis labels, no units, no takeaway message.



Missing the 'so what'

Features listed, but no impact, users, or benefit stated.



Last-minute printing

Printed the night before means typos frozen in ink and no time to fix.

Your 3-Minute Pitch, Engineered

0:00

Hook

One sentence that makes them care: “Every year, farmers lose 30% of crops to late disease detection.”

0:15

Problem

Who suffers, how big it is, why current solutions fall short.

0:45

Solution + Demo

What you built and how it works. Point at your diagram, show the demo. The heart of the pitch.

2:00

Results

Your best numbers: accuracy, speed, users tested, cost saved.

2:30

Impact & close

Who benefits, what is next, and a confident closing line.

Practice rule: rehearse the full pitch out loud at least 10 times: to friends, to a mirror, to your phone camera. Every team member must be able to deliver it alone, because judges often pick who speaks.

Delivery: What Judges See and Hear



Stand beside, never in front

Position yourself at the side of the poster so judges can see it while you talk.



Point as you speak

Touch the diagram, trace the flow, tap the chart. It connects your words to your visuals.



Eyes on judges, not the poster

Never read from the poster. Glance to point, then return to eye contact.



Project your voice

Fest halls are loud. Speak 20% louder and slower than feels natural.



Show you care

Enthusiasm is scored, even when it is not on the rubric. Smile, be proud of your work.

Team choreography

- Assign roles before the fest: one leads the pitch, one drives the demo, one leads Q&A, but everyone can do every role.
- Never leave the poster unattended during judging hours.
- When one teammate speaks, the others look at the judge, not at their phones.
- Keep a bottle of water and a spare copy of your pitch nearby.
- Dress one notch smarter than everyday college wear.

Presenting: Do vs. Don't



DO

- Open with your hook the moment a judge stops.
- Adapt: ask “Would you like the 1-minute or 3-minute version?”
- Use the poster as a map: walk judges through it section by section.
- Have a live demo or video ready to launch in under 10 seconds.
- Pause after key numbers to let them land.



DON'T

- Recite a memorized script word-for-word; it sounds robotic and breaks when interrupted.
- Read sentences directly off the poster.
- Talk only to one judge when a panel is present.
- Oversell: claiming “100% accurate, works for everyone” invites brutal follow-up questions.
- Argue with a judge or interrupt their question.

Answering Questions: The L-P-A-C Method



Listen fully

Let the judge finish. Never interrupt, never assume you know where the question is going.



Pause 2 seconds

A short silence looks thoughtful, not slow. It saves you from answering the wrong question.



Answer first, explain second

Give the direct answer in one sentence, then add reasoning: “Yes, because...” beats a 2-minute buildup.



Check back

End with “Does that answer your question?” It invites dialogue and shows confidence.

If a question is unclear: “Just to make sure I understand: are you asking about X or Y?” Clarifying is always better than guessing.

Handling the 4 Hardest Moments

You don't know the answer

"That's a great question. We haven't tested that yet. Based on our design, I'd expect... and it's on our future-work list."

Honesty + reasoning scores higher than a confident bluff. Judges can always tell.

The judge criticizes your work

"That's a fair point. We considered that and chose X because... but you're right that it's a limitation."

Thank, acknowledge, explain your trade-off. Never get defensive; they are testing your maturity.

You disagree with the judge

"I see your point. Our data showed something different though. May I show you this chart?"

Respectful pushback backed by evidence earns respect. Arguing without evidence loses it.

The demo fails live

"While it restarts, let me show you the recorded demo / walk you through the architecture."

Always carry a backup: recorded video on your phone + screenshots printed or on the poster.

Judge Etiquette: The Unwritten Rules



First 10 seconds matter

Smile, greet, introduce yourself and the project in one line. Offer a handshake if it feels natural.



It's a conversation, not an exam

Judges want dialogue. Ask them: "Would you like to see the demo?" Involve them.



Every member must speak

Judges often score team understanding. A silent teammate signals unequal work.



Own your limitations

State what your project does not do before they discover it. It converts a weakness into credibility.



Close warmly

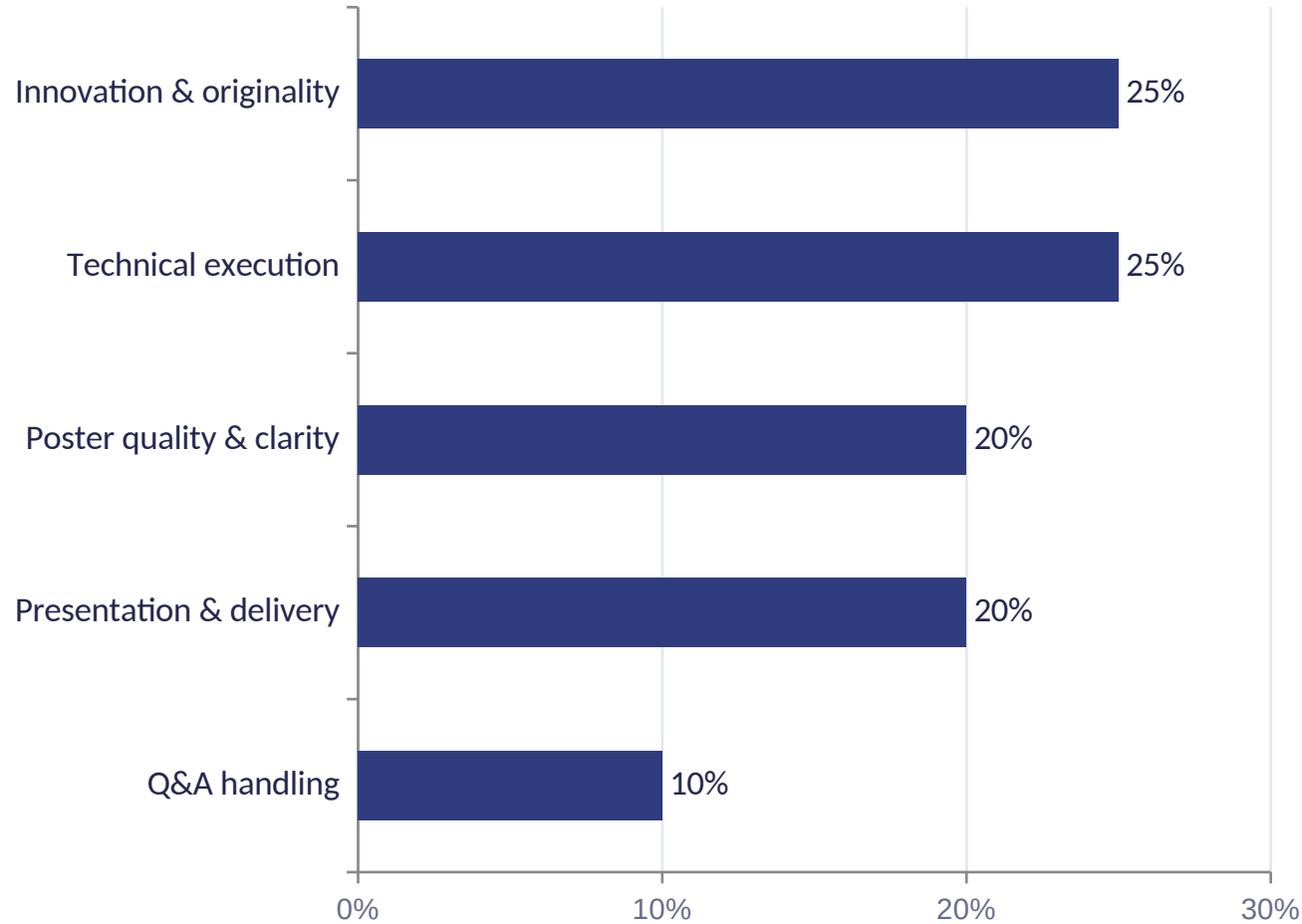
"Thank you for your time and feedback." Every judge, every time, win or lose.

What judges remember

After seeing 30 posters in a day, judges do not remember every feature. They remember:

- The team that explained a complex idea simply
- The demo that worked on the first try
- The student who answered a hard question honestly
- The poster they could understand from 2 meters away
- How the team made them feel: respected and engaged

What Judges Typically Score



Read the rubric like a map

- This is a typical rubric. Always ask organizers for the official one and design toward it.
- Half the score is communication (poster + delivery + Q&A), not raw technology. Weak presenters lose with strong projects every year.
- Track prizes (Best in AI, Best Social Impact, etc.) are scored separately, so say explicitly how your project fits your track.

THE PRIZE

Gold, Silver, Bronze, and Track Wins



GOLD

Complete story + flawless communication

Clear problem, working solution, measured results, confident Q&A. Nothing missing, nothing overstated.



SILVER

Strong project, small gaps

Usually loses gold on communication: unclear poster, shaky Q&A, or unpracticed pitch.



BRONZE

Good work, undersold

Solid technical effort whose story was hard to follow. The most preventable outcome in the room.



The winning equation: Real problem × working solution × measured results × clear story × confident Q&A. Zero in any one of these multiplies everything down. Most medals are lost on the last two.

The Countdown Checklist

1

1 week before

- Poster content final, reviewed by a mentor and one outsider
- Full pitch rehearsed 5+ times, timed under 3 minutes
- Mock Q&A: friends ask you the 10 hardest questions
- Demo tested on the devices you will actually bring

2

1 day before

- Poster printed (A0, 300 DPI, matte) and inspected corner to corner
- Backup demo video saved offline on two phones
- Print 5–10 A4 handouts of the poster with contact details
- Outfits, ID cards, laptop chargers, power bank packed

3

Fest morning

- Arrive early. Mount the poster straight, at eye level
- Full team walkthrough at the stand once, out loud
- Phones on silent; water bottle behind the table
- Take a deep breath. You know this project better than anyone in the room



**You know the standards.
Now own the room.**

A0 portrait • under 800 words • 40/40/20 • 3-minute pitch • L-P-A-C

Good luck at Innovation Fest 2026, Sunway College